



Preventing Spread of Respiratory Viruses When You're Sick



For Everyone

AUG. 18, 2025 • ESPAÑOL

WHAT TO KNOW

- Taking precautions when you are sick can help stop the spread of respiratory viruses to others.
- These actions can help reduce the risk of infecting people who are at higher risk of severe illness.



Recommendation

**Sick with a respiratory illness? Take p**
Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC)From a US
national ...

Watch on

[Sick with a respiratory illness? Take precautions to help stop the spread. \(Meta platforms\)](#)

When you may have a respiratory virus...



Stay home and away from others (including people you live with who are not sick) if you have respiratory virus symptoms that aren't better explained by another cause. These symptoms can include fever, chills, fatigue, cough, runny nose, and headache, among others.*

- You can go back to your normal activities when, for at least 24 hours, both are true:
 - Your symptoms are getting better overall, **and**
 - You have not had a fever (and are not using fever-reducing medication).
- When you go back to your normal activities, take added precautions over the next 5 days, such as taking [steps for cleaner air](#), practicing [good hygiene](#), wearing a well-fitted [mask](#), [physical distancing](#), or [testing](#) for times when you will be around other people. Taking precaution is especially important to protect people with factors that increase their risk of severe illness from respiratory viruses.
 - Keep in mind that you may still be able to spread the virus that made you sick, even if you are feeling better. You are likely to be less contagious after your symptoms fully resolve but some people, like those with immunocompromising conditions, can shed the virus for a long time.
 - If you develop a fever or you start to feel worse after you have gone back to normal activities, stay home and away from others again. If your symptoms are improving overall, and you have not had a fever and are not using fever-reducing medication for at least 24 hours, you can resume normal activities again. You should then take added precaution for the next 5 days as listed above.

*Symptoms may include but are not limited to chest discomfort, chills, cough, decrease in appetite, diarrhea, fatigue (tiredness), fever or feeling feverish, headache, muscle or body aches, new loss of taste or smell, runny or stuffy nose, sneezing, sore throat, vomiting, weakness, wheezing.

How it works

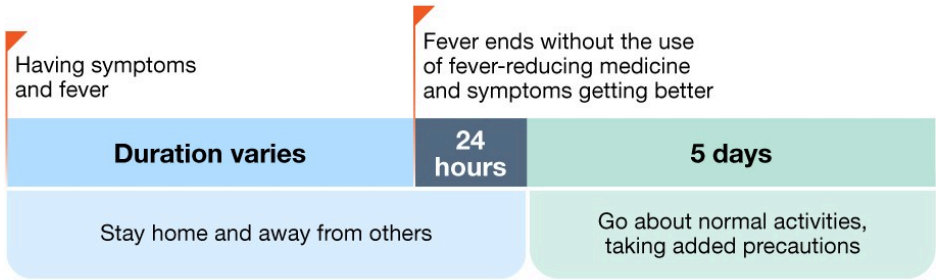
When you have a respiratory virus infection, you can spread it to others. How long someone can spread the virus depends on different factors, including how sick they are (severity), underlying medical conditions (such as having a weakened immune system), and how long their illness lasts (duration). This is not the same for everyone.

When your symptoms are getting better overall and you have not had a fever (and are not using fever-reducing medication) for at least 24 hours, you are typically less contagious, but it still takes more time for your body to fully get rid of the virus. During this time, you may still be able to spread the virus to others. Using precautions for the next 5 days can help reduce this risk. After this 5-day period, you are typically much less likely to be contagious. However, some people, especially people with weakened immune systems, can continue to spread the virus for a longer period of time. For COVID-19, taking a test can help you know how likely you are to spread the virus. A positive test tends to mean it is more likely that you can spread the virus to others at the time that you are tested.

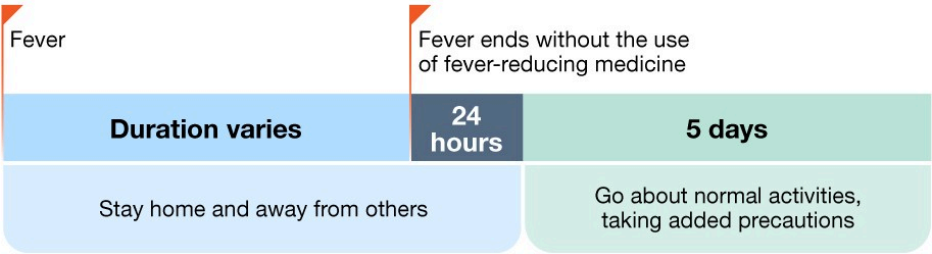
Example scenarios

For illustrative purposes, not to scale

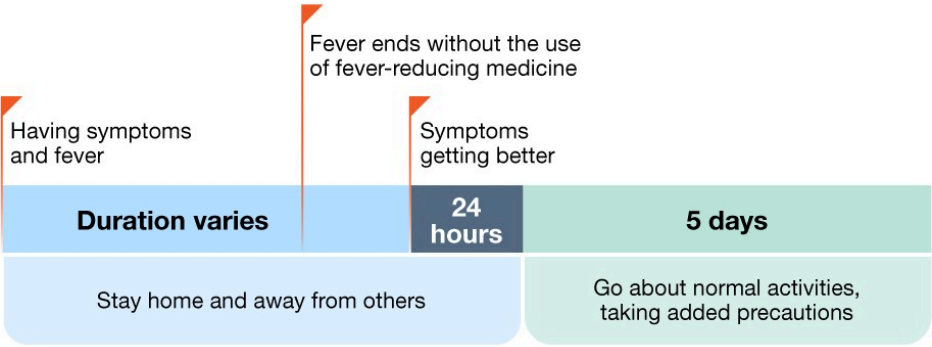
Example 1: Person with fever and symptoms.



Example 2: Person with fever but no other symptoms.



Example 3: Person with fever and other symptoms, fever ends but other symptoms take longer to improve.



Example 4: Person gets better and then gets a fever.

Symptoms	Symptoms getting better		Fever starts	Fever ends without the use of fever-reducing medicine	
Duration varies	24 hours	Duration varies	Duration varies	24 hours	5 days
Stay home and away from others		Go about normal activities, taking added precautions	Stay home and away from others		Go about normal activities, taking added precautions

If you never had symptoms but tested positive for a respiratory virus

You may be contagious. For the next 5 days: take added precaution, such as taking additional steps for cleaner air, hygiene, masks, physical distancing, and/or testing when you will be around other people indoors. This is especially important to protect people with factors that increase their risk of severe illness from respiratory viruses.

Steps you can take

- Consider using additional prevention tools, such as taking steps for cleaner air, practicing good hygiene, physical distancing, and wearing a well-fitted mask when you're home sick to protect others in your home. This can be especially helpful if you do not have space at home to stay entirely away from others.
- Monitor your symptoms. If you have an emergency warning sign (like trouble breathing or chest pain), seek emergency medical care immediately.

Get email updates

Enter your email address to receive CDC's Respiratory Health and Immunization Newsletter, a quarterly source for tips to prevent respiratory illnesses, vaccination updates, and more.

Sign up now

Steps organizations can take

- Advise people to stay home if they are sick.
- Provide employees with paid time off and develop flexible leave and telework policies to support workers to stay home if sick or to care for sick family members.
- Adopt flexible cancellation or refund policies for customers who are sick.

Notice

CDC offers separate, specific guidance for healthcare settings ([COVID-19](#), [flu](#), and [general infection prevention and control](#)). [Federal civil rights laws](#) may require reasonable modifications or reasonable accommodations in various circumstances. Nothing in this guidance is intended to detract from or supersede those laws.

SOURCES AND PAGE INFO

CONTENT SOURCE:

[National Center for Immunization and Respiratory Diseases \(NCIRD\)](#)

ABOUT THIS PAGE

Published: July 17, 2024

Updated: August 18, 2025

This page was last updated on this date. Updates may include minor edits, image changes, or other modifications to page content.

Reviewed: August 18, 2025

The information on this page was last reviewed by subject matter experts to ensure accuracy.